



EXTENT OF THE EMPIRE ▲

Cyrus the Great conquered the Median Empire, of which Persis was a part, in 550 BCE, then the empire of Lydia in 546 BCE, and Babylon in 539 BCE. Under later kings the empire continued to grow and at its height under Darius I stretched from southeastern Europe to northwest India—the largest empire the world had ever seen.



The satrap's larger size shows his high rank.

Richly decorated robe



▲ ROYAL ARMY

The Persian army included an elite force of 10,000 troops that served as the king's personal bodyguards. They were called "Immortals" because as soon as one died, they were replaced to keep the number at 10,000. The mosaic above shows one of Darius I's loyal soldiers, at his palace in Susa.



▲ LATER PERSIA

After being defeated by Greece, Persian power was revived first under the Parthian Empire (247 BCE–224 CE), followed by the Sasanian Empire (224–651 CE). Both came into conflict with the Roman and Byzantine empires. This coin shows Ardashir I (reigned 224–242 CE), the founder of the Sasanian Empire.

Face of an Egyptian god to offer protection